



SABAL DAS/www.indiatodaymag.com

face. "I wanted to learn from people, understand the way they lived. The way we moved at that time, that was necessary for the grounding of a politician."

Simple words. And he also turned out to be a simple man when we went over to shoot him. I still remember the amazement on the faces of my unit members when we entered Indira Bhavan, where he lived in retirement. Everybody expected an army of security guards and domestic help. Instead, we encountered a man with a very simple lifestyle. Uncluttered rooms with minimum furniture (one room full of books, though) and just a handful of security guards and a cook (who used to put his food in a basic steel tiffin box, not even a hot case).

A man of few words, his face would light up with excitement when recollecting his past, but he could go on speaking for hours. But in one regard he was a *pukka sahib*. He had to have his lunch sharp at one.

It was hard to imagine, but the father of panchayat system in the state was critical about it. "We had tried to create the three-tier panchayat system for the benefit of the common people," he said. "But now I know there is corruption there and I have to control them." He had understood it was the age of a new market economy. Money did

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matter and that value system had entered the party, too. Basu denied any rift with his successor, Buddhadeb Bhattacharya: "We like him. He is a serious comrade." He also repeated his belief that not accepting prime minister-ship was a historic blunder, but he added: "Not for me, but for the party and for Bengal." He regretted also that comrades no longer read books on sociology and history, which he felt was a must. "In the past 10 to 15 years, we have hardly had any classes in our party. Perhaps, because we are in power, members think we don't need those classes any more." He seemed sad and regretful about the change.

A master politician, the nuances of power play were not unknown to him. "When you leave power, certain elements who join the party for power soon fade away," he said. His biggest regret was that the education system of Bengal had lost its standing and that young students preferred to move out of the state.

But, above all, Jyoti Basu was a complete *bhadralok*, a perfect gentleman. His kind of honesty is difficult to imagine in today's time.

Filmmaker Goutam Ghose made a documentary Jyoti Babur Songe in 2005